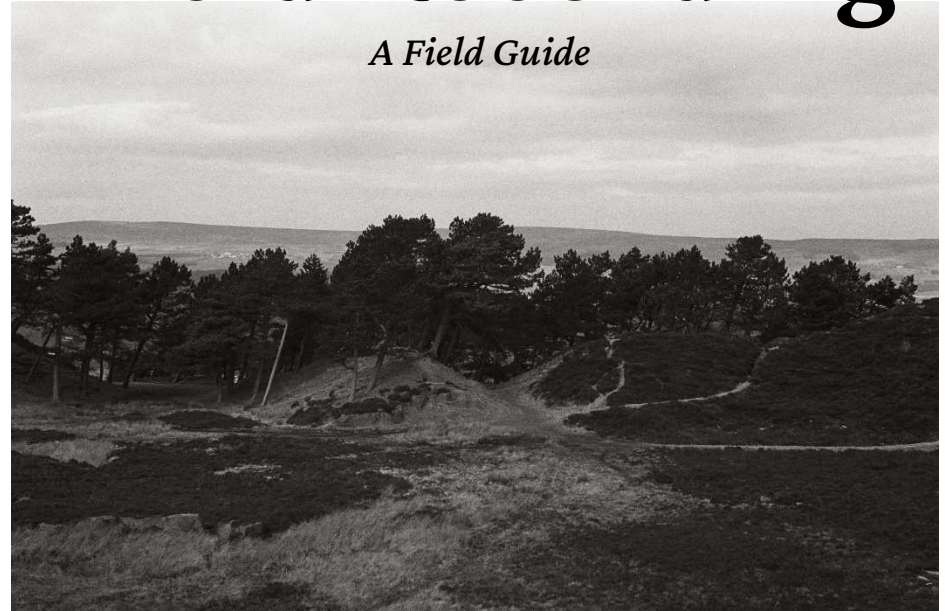


Field Recording

A Field Guide



‘I knew in that field I could listen to all sounds, all music.’

John Berger, *Field* (1971)

TASK #1: The Tuning of The World

Find and record a *sustained* sound.

If you can sing the pitch, do so.

TASK #2: Pulse Finder (after Pauline Oliveros' *A Study In Pulses*)

The world is full of audible patterns and pulses.

Try to record the most interesting sonic patterns or pulses (repeating sounds) that you can find. Pulses might be short and fast, or (very) long and slow.

TASK #3: Alien Worlds

Microphones can capture unusual sounds that we might normally ignore.

Use your microphone to find unfamiliar sounds or sounds from a new perspective. The sounds' source should not be immediately recognisable.

Some examples:

Rain, as heard from inside a plastic bottle

Dried leaves crumbling in hand

Wind whistling through a tunnel

A wire fence humming in the breeze

Something closer than you normally encounter it

Field recording is the capture of sounds *out there*, in the field.

Listen carefully, then press record.

As you plan your field recordings, think about...

1. **How long will you record for?** 3 seconds? 3 minutes? 3 hours?
2. **When will you make the recording?** Right now? At Midnight? At Dawn? At the weekend? In winter?
3. **Where are you recording?**
4. **How close will you be to your sound?** A close-up intimate sound? A more distant recording that captures the general 'ambience' of your location? How much detail will you record?
5. **Is the perspective moving, or stationary?** Are you moving, or standing still while recording?
6. **How will you edit these recordings later?** Will you edit together tiny fragments that we pick out, or layer together multiple recordings? Will you cut between sounds, or crossfade them? Will you filter out unwanted noise or traffic?*

* Prompts adapted from Michael Pisaro's 'Ten framing considerations of the field'.

Getting started with a ZOOM H4n recorder

1. **Find a sound to record.** Get in position. Don't move the recorder while you're recording or you'll hear rustling. Better to not hold it at all: balance it (securely) on something steady. Do you need a wind shield?
2. **Switch on the recorder** using the switch on the side.
3. **Arm the recorder** (get it ready to record) by pressing the red RECORD button once. You should now be able to hear incoming signal, and see it on the meters.
4. **Set the gain** with the side buttons. (Listen on headphones and check it sounds okay!)

Set the gain carefully, with a good signal to noise ratio: High enough to be clear, but not so high that loud noises might cause it to clip (go over 0 dB).

To start, try setting your gain so the average incoming signal is around -6 dB.

5. **To start recording press the red RECORD button again.** See the timer counting up? You're recording!
6. **Record the sound...**
7. **Press STOP.** You're done!

Later, import the recorded audio files to your computer and give them useful (descriptive) names. Either plug in via USB and select 'Storage' on the screen, or use the SD card. *Once you've backed up your files, remember to delete the files off the SD card so that it's clear for the next person to use.*

Using a DAW like REAPER or Audacity, clean up your recordings (adjust gain, EQ) and edit out the unnecessary parts (pauses, button noises, false takes, etc.)

Some artists who use field recordings

- **Jana Winderen** – *Energy Field* (2010, Touch Music)
- **Chris Watson** – *Weather Report* (2003, Touch Music)
- **Hildegard Westerkamp** – *Kit's Beach Soundwalk* (1989)
- **Jakob Kirkegaard** – *Four Rooms* (2008, Touch Music)
- **Toshiya Tsunoda** – *Extract of Field Recording Archive* (2019, [erstwhile](#))
- **Lawrence English** – *Evocation at Peron* (2021, [Superpang](#))
- **Celer** – *Xièxie* (2019)
- **Izabela Dłużyk** – *Soundscapes of Summer* (2016, [LOM](#))
- **Francisco López** – *untitled #284* (2011)
- **Set Fire To Flames** – *Sings Reign Rebuilder* ([Alien8](#), 2001)
- **Tine Surel Lange** – *My Favourite Places* (2022)
- **Graham Lamkin** – *Salmon Run* (2007)

Build your own 'Contact' microphone!

Building a contact mic – a microphone that records physical vibrations, rather than sound waves – is incredibly cheap and easy. All you need is a simple piezo transducer disc. Solder up a cable with a jack connector (*Signal* connects to the central crystal, *ground* connects to the outer metal disk), and off you go!²



For bonus points, seal your contact microphone in epoxy resin to make it waterproof, and you've made a **hydrophone** – an underwater microphone!

Image from Nicolas Collins'

Handmade Electronic Music, p. 28

Oliver Thurley, 2023
19/09/23

² John Grzinich, 'Building Contact Microphones', <http://maaheli.ee/main/building-contact-microphones/>

Nicolas Collins, 'How To Make A Contact Mike' in *Handmade Electronic Music* (New York: Routledge, 2006), 27–36